

Introduction to Microeconomics

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Office Hours | 348 Robins, 10 - 12 Wednesday

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Course Description

This course is about decisionmakers with 1) preferences who 2) face scarcity. Each of us make hundreds of choices every day. And each of our choices plays out in our social and political environment. In this class we will consider how decisionmakers make choices and how individuals' choices in groups interact. Economists ask, "What decisions should and do we make when we can't have everything?" Tools in this class will organize your thinking about the decisions we face as a society and as individuals.

At a high level, we will begin by building a model of cooperation, production, and shared benefit. Then we will look at how types of markets can coordinate decision-making between large groups of decisionmakers. In this framework, we will look at cases when markets work imperfectly and how government policy can address market failures. We will consider firms, market power, and how they behave in markets over time.

In this class there will be fewer traditional lectures than you might be familiar with, exams are always open book, and homework is submitted and returned online. Economics relies heavily on mathematics as a cognitive stepstool, and proficiency in algebra is helpful for this class. But no matter who you are or where you're coming from, if you're willing to work hard then you are more than capable of participating in the class. Welcome!

Course Resources

There are many resources available to help you master the material. Some of your time should be spent on homework, some on reading, and some in discussion with me and your colleagues in class. Economics is best learned through practice, so put in the time to master it. Class resources include:

- **Blackboard** holds the class together, where you'll find
 - Announcements
 - Tutorials (concept videos)
 - Demos (practice problem videos)
 - Homework
 - Study guides
 - Miniexam checklists

- **The Textbook** for the class is Gregory Mankiw's, *Principles of Microeconomics*, in the 5th edition. You can find the text with a simple search. More recent editions include updated examples but no new topics. Any addition of the text will do, even other principles of microeconomics books are usable, but will involve more work on your part. Let me know if you have questions.
- **Box** will be the portal to collect and return assignments.
- **Office Hours** are a great resource so come see me!

Grading

Grades don't belong in an ideal world. No matter your grade in the class, you belong in my classroom. All assignments, from homework to in class assessments, are designed to push you to do excellent work and flex your critical thinking skills with as little unpleasantness as possible. There will be no busywork, trick questions, or high-stakes exams. And in return I expect you to work hard.

Your highest grades will count for a relatively large portion of your grade. This has the effect of lowering the stakes but also means you cannot simply add up the point totals to see how you are doing in the class. Your final grade will be based on the weighted average of all your scores in the following way:

- **Check-Ins (10%)** are a low-stakes environment in which you will verbally deliver one randomly chosen homework or mini-exam question to the instructor and a group of peers. Times will be scheduled.
- **Homework ($5 \times 5\% = 25\%$)** assignments are due by the beginning of class. Assignments will be completed using a template provided on Dropbox. Solutions will be reviewed in class, so late assignments won't be accepted. Working together is strongly encouraged but all work should be your own and will be turned in individually. Your lowest homework grade will be dropped.
- **Minixams ($2 \times 20\% + 2 \times 10\% + 1 \times 5\% = 65\%$)** are designed for you to demonstrate competency and mastery of the most recent topics. There will be six open-book minixams. Minixams will take place during the first part of class. Your lowest minixam score will be dropped. Your top two minixam scores will count as 20% of your grade. Your third and fourth highest minixam scores will count as 10% of your grade. Your fifth highest minixam will count as 5% of your grade. More details will be made available at the time.

During the minixams: 1) You may use material from your notes and the textbook; 2) You may not use any material that requires internet access. Your exam should be your own and is subject to the Academic Conduct Code (below). If you are **at all unclear** about a particular piece of material with respect to these two guidelines, it is your responsibility to clarify its appropriateness with the instructor. Please email with any questions about what constitutes an academic violation. We take this very seriously.

Missed work cannot be made up post-hoc. Contact me before the due date to apply for an extension if you anticipate submitting late work.

Disability Services

If you have a disability, contact both the instructor and the Office of Disability Services, Boatwright Memorial Library B2-10, (804) 662-5001 as early as possible in the term. They will verify your disability and determine reasonable accommodations for this course.

Academic Conduct Code

All students are expected to adhere to the standards of the Student Honor Code. Any violation is a serious matter. Any student engaged in cheating, plagiarism, or other acts of academic dishonesty would be subject to disciplinary action, may 1) receive a zero on the exam counting for 20% of their class grade, or 2) receive an F in the class.

Final Notes

1. This class is designed for you to succeed. Work hard, be prepared, and don't hesitate to seek us out when you need help!
2. Students are responsible for all covered materials, announcements, and assignments.
3. I expect you to complete and upload your work early enough that you have time to work through any technology problems you run into. Please email me as soon as you run into problems.
4. I reserve the right to modify materials/procedures.

Course Schedule (*Tentative*)

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Week 1. (starting Aug. 22)		Week 2. (starting Aug. 29)	
Topics. Introduction to Class; Production Possibilities		Topics. Four Quad PPF; Markets; Demand	
Ch. 1, 2, 3		Ch. 4	Due. Pre Homework
Week 3. (starting Sept. 5)		Week 4. (starting Sept. 12)	
Topics. Equilibrium; Government Policy		Topics. Consumers; Producers; Efficiency	
Ch. 5, 6	Due. Homework 1 (Tr)	Ch. 7	Due. Miniexam 1 (Tr)
Week 5. (starting Sept. 19)		Week 6. (starting Sept. 26)	
Topics. International Trade		Topics. Externalities	
Ch. 8, 9	Due. Homework 2 (Tr)	Ch. 10, 11	Due. Miniexam 2 (Tr)
Week 7. (starting Oct. 10)		Week 8. (starting Oct. 17)	
Topics. Game Theory and Public Goods		Topics. Common Resources	
Ch. 11	Due. Homework 3 (Tr)	Ch. 13	Due. Miniexam 3 (Tr)
Week 9. (starting Oct. 24)		Week 10. (starting Oct. 31)	
Topics. Production Costs		Topics. Monopoly	
Ch. 14	Due. Homework 4 (Tr)	Ch. 15	Due. Miniexam 4 (Tr)
Week 11. (starting Nov. 7)		Week 12. (starting Nov. 14)	
Topics. Monopolistically Competitive Firms		Topics. Oligopolistic Firms	
Ch. 16	Due. Homework 5 (Tr)	Ch. 17	Due. Miniexam 5 (Tr)
Week 13. (starting Nov. 21)		Week 14. (starting Nov. 28)	
Topics. Factors of Production; Labor Market		Topics. Consumer Choice	
Ch. 18	Due. Extra sleep: 5 hours or more	Ch. 21	Due. Homework 6 (Tr)
Week 15. (starting Dec. 6)			
Due. Miniexam 6 (Tr)			

While the final grade breaks will depend on the exact distribution of scores, the worst case scenario is as follows:

97.0% and above	A+	93.0% to 96.9%	A	90.0% to 92.9%	A-
87.0% to 89.9%	B+	83.0% to 86.9%	B	80.0% to 82.9%	B-
77.0% to 79.9%	C+	73.0% to 76.9%	C	70.0% to 72.9%	C-
67.0% to 69.9%	D+	63.0% to 66.9%	D	60.0% to 62.9%	D-

Below 60% is an F. All grades are rounded to the nearest tenth of a percent.